Topic 3 — Vedic Civilization

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Vedic Period | Rigvedic Society | Later Vedic Society | Vedic Administration | Rigvedic Economy | Later Vedic Economy | Political Institutions | Sabha | Samiti | Vidhata | Vedic Religion | Four Vedas | Brahmanas | Aranyakas | Upanishads | Vedangas | Painted Grey Ware (PGW) | Iron Age in India

Sources baked in: NCERT *Themes in Indian History* I, RS Sharma, Ghatnachakra Vedic Age (B–31+), UPPCS Prelims PYQs 2018–2025, UKPCS Prelims 2025 (Yajurveda Krishna/Shukla) **Weight:** ★★★ — Rigvedic vs Later Vedic, assemblies, officials, Yajurveda schools **Last verified:** September 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A — purely historical; no scheme/report/appointment surface

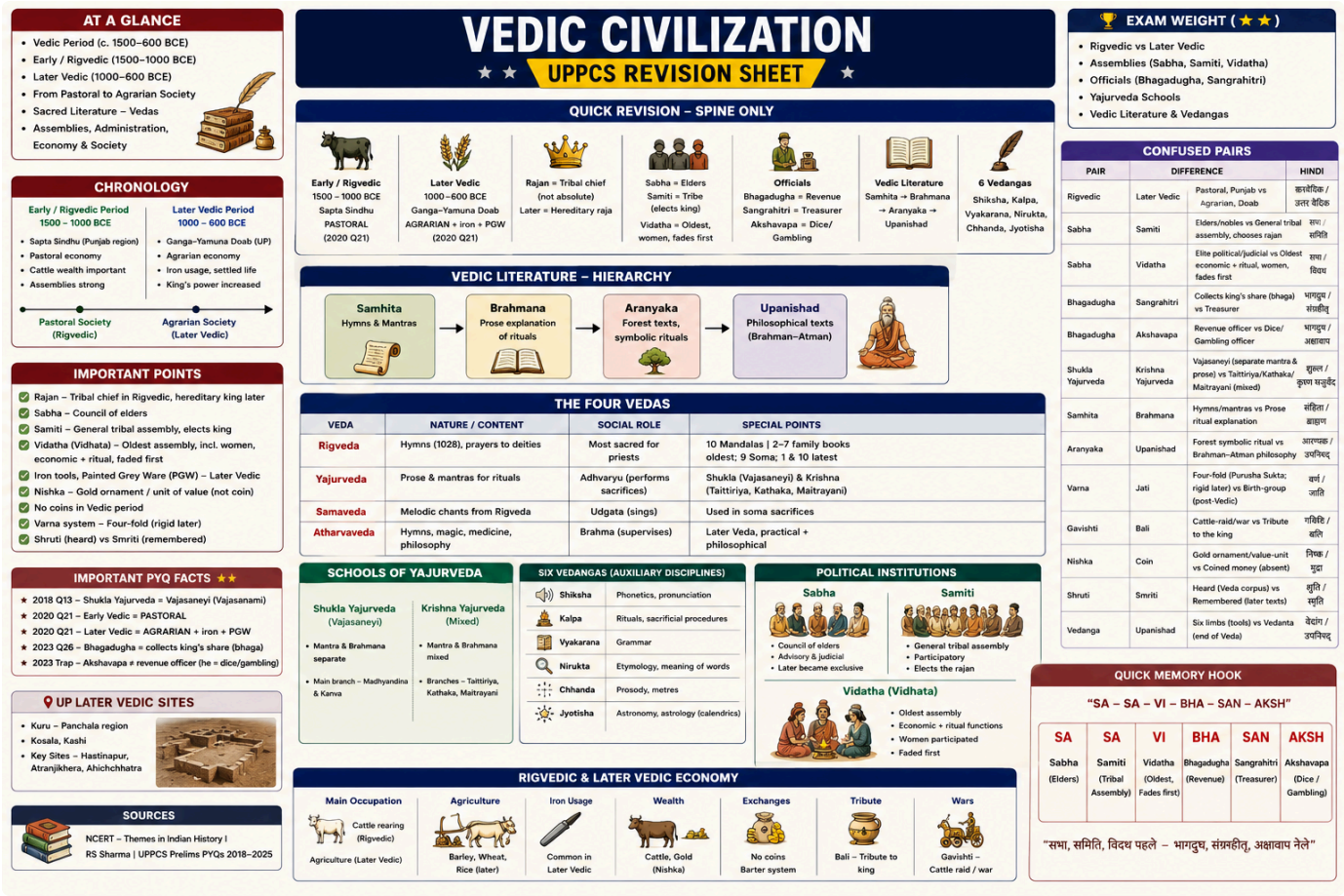
Books and Writers — Vedic Age

Book–writer pairs | Vedanga authors | corpus heads stay without personal writers

Book / text	Writer / authority	What it is for
Ashtadhyayi (अष्टाध्यायी)	**Panini** (पाणिनि)	Vyakarana; Classical Sanskrit grammar
Nirukta (निरुक्त)	**Yaska** (यास्क)	Etymology Vedanga
Chhanda / metre tradition	**Pingala**	Metre Vedanga

- The Samhitas, Brahmanas, Aranyakas, and Upanishads are **corpus** heads. They do not carry a single match-list author like Panini.
- **Panini** is the usual Vyakarana name. Do not swap him with Yaska.

Logic: *Ashtadhyayi* = **Panini**. *Nirukta* = **Yaska**.



3.1 Vedic Period

Indo-Aryan culture of Vedic Sanskrit texts | Early ~1500–1000 BCE | Later ~1000–600 BCE

- **Veda** (वेद) means knowledge. The post-Harappan textual culture of the Indo-Aryans is called the **Vedic** age.
- **Arya** in classical Sanskrit means a **noble** person. Older booklet keys sometimes call it a "superior race"; standard teaching treats Arya as a **cultural–linguistic** self-designation, not a modern racial science label.
- Homeland theories differ by named author, not by settled proof.
- **Bal Gangadhar Tilak** (बाल गंगाधर तिलक) argued the **Arctic / North Pole** in *The Arctic Home in the Vedas*; historians generally reject it.
- **Max Müller** stressed **Central Asia** (most widely accepted view).
- **Swami Dayanand Saraswati** argued **Tibet** (*Satyarth Prakash*).
- **Boghazkoi Inscription** (Asia Minor / Turkey, 1400 BC) mentions 4 Rigvedic deities: **Indra, Varuna, Mitra, and Nasatyas**, confirming antiquity and Indo-Iranian linguistic links.
- Other writers place Aryans in South Russia, Tibet, the Danube, Kashmir, or "seven Indus states."
- The **Early / Rigvedic** heartland is **Sapta Sindhu**, the north-west Punjab belt.
- The seven rivers are **Sindhu** (Indus), **Vitasta** (Jhelum), **Asikni / Asakini** (Chenab), **Parushni** (Ravi), **Vipas / Vipasa** (Beas), **Sutudri / Shutudri** (Sutlej), and **Saraswati**.
- Afghanistan rivers named in the Rigveda include **Kubha** (Kabul), **Krumu** (Kurram), **Gomati** (गोमती) (Gomal), and **Suvastu** (Swat).
- **Sindhu** is mentioned **most often** and is called **Hiranyayi**; it empties toward the Arabian Sea.

- **Saraswati** is the **most sacred** river — *Matetama*, *Devitama*, *Naditama*.
- **Yamuna** (यमुना) appears a few times; **Ganga** (गंगा) appears once in early Rigvedic memory.
- **Sadaneera** is identified with the **Gandak** (गंडक); **Drishadvati** with the Ghaggar belt in many notes.
- Aryans called the doab fringe **Brahmarshi Desh**, the Himalaya–Vindhya belt **Madhya Desh**, and later the wider north **Aryavarta**.
- **Later Vedic** culture shifts **east** into the **Ganga–Yamuna doab** of western–central UP.
- It then reaches **Kosala**, **Kashi**, and **Videha**.
- The archaeological marker of Later Vedic is **Painted Grey Ware (PGW)**, about **1100–600 BCE**, with **iron**.
- Early Vedic has **no** Harappan-style cities.
- **Ayas** in the Rigveda means copper or bronze, not iron.
- Iron appears as **shyama ayas** or **krishna ayas** in Later Vedic texts. Early iron in the doab is often linked to sites such as **Atranjikhera** (~1000 BCE band).
- The language is **Vedic Sanskrit**, older than Panini's Classical Sanskrit. Avestan of **Iran** shares close kinship with Rigvedic language.
- The Vedic age ends around **600 BCE**. Mahajanapadas, Buddhism, and Jainism follow.
- There was **no** Vedic empire.

> **Logic:** Rigvedic = **northwest pastoral**. Later Vedic = **Gangetic agrarian**. Trap: "Vedic period = only UP."
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2020, Q21]:** Rigvedic Society = Pastoral; Later Vedic = Agrarian; IVC = Urban; Medieval = Land Lordism. *(See Q2 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

3.2 Rigvedic Society

Tribal · pastoral · jana / vis · women relatively free · varna not yet a cage

- The social unit is the **jana** (tribe) and the **vis** (clan).
- Loyalty is to kin, not to a fixed territory.
- There is no janapada-state.
- The **rajan** is a war-chief and ritual head.
- He is chosen with assembly consent.
- He is **not** an absolute hereditary king.
- **Cattle are wealth.**
- Wars are often **gavishti / gaveshana** (search for cows / battle for cattle). Wealthy man is called **Gomat**, daughter is **Duhitri** (milker of cows), distance is **Gavyuti**, and evening time is **Godhuli**.
- **Battle of Ten Kings (Dasrajan War):** Fought on the banks of river **Parushni (Ravi)**. King **Sudas** of the Bharata clan (Tritsu family, assisted by sage **Vasishtha**) defeated an alliance of 10 kings (5 Aryan + 5 non-Aryan) led by sage **Vishvamitra**.
- **Rigvedic Rivers (Nadisukta):** Kubha (Kabul), Vitasta (Jhelum), Asikni (Chenab), Parushni (Ravi), Vipas (Beas), Sutudri (Sutlej), Drishadvati (Ghaggar), Sadanira (Gandak), Gomati (Gomal), Suvastu (Swat).
- **Dasas** and **Dasyus** are rival groups in the hymns.
- **Panis** are cattle-keepers or traders, often hostile in the hymns.

- Women hymn-composers (**Brahmavadinis**) include **Lopamudra** (wife of Agastya), **Visvavara**, **Ghosha**, **Sikata**, and **Apala**.
- Women could attend the **Sabha**.
- Women could attend the **Vidatha**.
- There is no sati, purdah, or child-marriage as a system.
- **Varna** is named in the **Purusha Sukta** (Rigveda **X.90**), a **late** hymn. **Shudra** appears clearly here; earlier hymns stress three functional groups more loosely.
- The **Panchajana** tribes are **Yadu, Turvasa, Druhyu, Anu, and Puru**. **Kikata** is **not** one of them.
- **Kul / kula** is the smallest family unit. Society is **patriarchal**.
- **Gotra** in early Rigvedic usage can mean a cow-pen / herd; lineage sense grows later.
- The cow is **aghanya** — "not to be killed." Cattle are wealth and a medium of exchange.
- Occupation is still flexible in Early Vedic.
- Early Vedic **varna** is still **flexible** occupation; the later four-fold *jati* system is a Later Vedic growth.
- Religion is of **nature gods**, with **no temples and no idols**.
- Chief Early Vedic gods are **Indra**, **Agni** (अग्नि), **Soma**, and **Varuna**.
- Houses are of wood and thatch.
- The **ratha** is a horse-chariot.
- There are no stone cities, no iron, and no coins.
- Clothing terms include **vasa** (lower) and **adhivasa** (upper). Craft terms include **taksha** (carpenter), **karma** (metal-worker), **veknat** (moneylender), and **aritri** (boatman).

> **Logic:** Rigvedic society is **Pastoral**, not agrarian. Later Vedic = agrarian. **Yava** = **barley** (not millet).

3.3 Later Vedic Society

Settled agrarian · iron plough · janapadas · rigid varna · women lose ground

- Iron and the plough open Gangetic forests.
- Surplus supports specialists.
- The economy type in match-lists is **Agrarian** — not pastoral like the Rigvedic phase.
- The **jana** becomes a **janapada** (जनपद), a territorial kingdom.
- Famous Later Vedic polities are **Kuru** and **Panchala**.
- **Kosala** is a Later Vedic polity in eastern UP.
- **Kashi** is a Later Vedic polity.
- **Videha** is a Later Vedic polity further east.
- Four varnas **harden**: Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra.
- Shudras are denied **upanayana**.
- **Gotra** exogamy appears.
- Anuloma and pratiloma marriage rules appear.
- **Women** drop from assemblies and from Vedic study.
- Child marriage begins to show.

- There are no more hymn-composers of the Early type.
- **Gargi** is a Later Vedic **exception** in Upanishadic debate.
- **Maitreyi** is another Later Vedic **exception**.
- They are not the social average.
- Four **ashramas** are systematized: Brahmacharya, Grihastha, Vanaprastha, and Sannyasa.
- About sixteen samskaras appear in later lists.
- Land grants to priests (**brahmadeya**) start the landlord pattern.
- Assemblies weaken. The king claims more.
- Thought shifts from ritual Brahmanas to forest Aranyakas.
- It then reaches the **Upanishads**, which put jnana over yajna.
- Religious focus shifts: **Prajapati**, **Vishnu**, and **Rudra** rise; royal **Rajasuya / Ashvamedha / Vajapeya** advertise kingship.

> **Logic:** "Women equal throughout the Vedic age" is false. The decline is **Later Vedic**.

3.4 Vedic Administration

Rajan + purohita + senani core | Later Vedic adds revenue staff | no Mauryan bureaucracy

- The **rajan** is the chief or king.
- In Later Vedic he becomes **hereditary**.
- He takes a divine aura.
- A household of **ratnins**, the jewel-officers of consecration, grows around him.
- The **purohita** (पुरोहित) is chief priest and political adviser.
- **Vasishtha** served Sudas as purohita.
- **Visvamitra** is the rival priest in that tradition.
- The **senani** (सेनानी) is the army commander.
- The **gramani** (ग्रामिणी) is the village head and is also listed among the ratnins.
- The **bhagadugha** is the **revenue collector**.
- He takes the king's **bhaga** (share) of produce or booty.
- The **sangrahitri** is the treasurer or chamberlain.
- The **akshavapa** is a real Later Vedic **ratnin**.
- His charge is **dice and gambling**, and sometimes accounts.
- He is **not** the revenue collector. Revenue is **Bhagadugha**.
- The **suta** is the charioteer or bard.
- The **kshattri** is another ratnin.
- The **takshan** is the carpenter.
- **Govikartana** appears in ratnin lists.
- **Palagala** also appears in ratnin lists.

Ratnin (jewel-officer)	Role
Purohita	Chief priest and royal adviser
Senani	Army commander
Gramani	Village head
Suta	Charioteer / court bard
Kshattri	Chamberlain-type officer
Bhagadugha	Revenue collector of the king's **bhaga**
Sangrahitri	Treasurer
Akshavapa	Dice / gambling officer
Takshan	Carpenter
Govikartana	Cowherd / cattle officer in lists
Palagala	Another ratnin name in Later Vedic lists

- **Bali** is tribute.
- **Bhaga** is the king's share.
- Later **shulka** is a toll.
- Spies appear in later texts.
- In family vocabulary, **kula**, **vamsha**, and **gotra** belong together; **kosha** (कोष) means **treasury**, not a kinship term.
- The system is still clan-based. It is **not** Ashokan district officers.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2023, Q26]: Bhagadugha** = Revenue / tax collector; **Samgrahitri** = Treasurer in Vedic Ratnin list. *(See Q1 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

3.5 Rigvedic Economy

Cattle-wealth · barter · barley · no coins · no iron plough

- Wealth is counted in **cows**.
- **Gavishti** is a cattle-raid, not a tax.
- Agriculture exists but is **secondary**.
- **Yava** (barley) is known in Early Vedic. Do not match *yava* to millet.
- Later crop vocabulary includes **vrihi** (rice), **mudga** (mung), and **ikshu** (sugarcane).
- Wheat (**godhuma**) and rice become important **later**, with the iron plough.
- Exchange is by **barter**.
- **Nishka** is a gold necklace used as a **value standard**. It is **not** a coin. Later ages use *nishka* as a coin-name.
- **Hiranya** means gold.

- There are **no** punch-marked coins yet.
- Crafts include copper and bronze work, leather, pottery, and **chariot**-making.
- The soma plant is brought from the mountains for ritual.
- There is no private landed estate of the Later Vedic grant type.
- Pasture is tribal.
- **Dakshina** is a gift to the priest after yajna. It is not a land-revenue department.

> **Logic:** Trap — "nishka was a gold coin of the Rigvedic age."

Later Vedic Economy

Iron plough · surplus grain · bali / bhaga · brahmadeya · path to second urbanisation

- Later Vedic society became **agrarian** because the **iron plough** opened Gangetic forest and supported **surplus grain**.
- **Land grants to priests (brahmadeya)** began the pattern of religious landlords.
- **Bali** (tribute) and **bhaga** (king's share) were collected.
- **Shulka** (toll) appears in later texts.
- Iron tools are the material backbone — linked to **PGW** layers in the doab.
- Crafts and specialist priests grow with surplus.
- Trade still uses barter and metal value-units more than coined money.
- This agrarian base supports the **second urbanisation** and the rise of **sixteen mahajanapadas** from about the sixth century BCE.

> **Logic:** Match-list fact — Rigvedic = **Pastoral**; Later Vedic = **Agrarian**.

Rigvedic vs Later Vedic — Comparison Framework

Point	Rigvedic	Later Vedic
Territory	**Sapta Sindhu** (Punjab)	**Ganga–Yamuna doab** and beyond
Economy	**Pastoral** (cattle wealth)	**Agrarian** (iron plough, surplus)
Polity	elected **rajan** + strong Sabha–Samiti–Vidatha	hereditary **raja**; weaker assemblies
Society	flexible occupation; women freer	rigid **varna**; women lose ground
Religion	nature gods; **Indra** tops hymns	ritual kings' yajnas; **Prajapati / Vishnu / Rudra** rise
Archaeology	no cities; **ayas** = copper/bronze	**PGW** + **iron** (*shyama ayas*)

Vedic Religion and Ritual

Nature hymns + fire sacrifice | no temples · no idols | Early Indra → Later Prajapati / Vishnu / Rudra

Rigvedic gods and hymn counts

About **33** gods are grouped in three layers: **earth**, **air (antariksha)**, and **sky**.

God	Approx. Rigvedic hymns	Role / fact
Indra	**~250** (largest)	War god, rain-bringer, slayer of **Vritra**; called **Purandara** (fort-breaker)
Agni	**~200** (second)	Fire god; carries offerings to other gods
Soma	**~120**	Ritual drink-god; Mandala **IX** is the Soma book
Ashvins	**~50+**	Twin healer / dawn horsemen gods
Varuna	fewer (but high prestige)	Guardian of **rita** (cosmic / moral order)
Mitra (मित्र -)	paired with Varuna	Treaty / friendship; often **Mitra–Varuna**
Maruts	storm band with Indra	Wind / storm companions
Ushas	dawn hymns	Dawn goddess
Savitr	solar	Invoked in the **Gayatri** (RV III.62.10)
Surya / Pushan	solar group	Sun and path / cattle-path gods
Vishnu	few / **minor**	Three strides myth; **not** yet supreme
Rudra	few / **minor**	Fierce storm / healer; later rises as Shiva

- Early Vedic religion is **polytheistic** nature worship through **hymns and fire sacrifice** (yajna).
- There are **no temples** and **no idols** in the Rigvedic pattern.
- **Rita** is cosmic / natural order; **Varuna** is its chief guardian (**Ritasyagopa**).
- **Dharma** in Vedic usage points to duty and ordinance that keep order; **rita** is the impersonal universal law. Both appear from the Rigveda onward.
- **Brihaspati** is the priest / teacher of the gods (**Deva-guru**).
- The **Boghaz-köi** (Boğazköy) inscription from Asia Minor / Hittite lands (about **14th century BCE**) names **Indra, Varuna, Mitra, and Nasatya** — proof of Indo-Aryan god-names outside India.
- **Dyaus** (sky) and **Prithvi** (earth) are older nature pair names in the hymns.

Later Vedic religion

- Kings advertise power through **Rajasuya** (consecration), **Ashvamedha** (horse sacrifice / territory claim), and **Vajapeya**.
- **Prajapati** rises as a creator / ritual-supreme figure.
- **Vishnu** and **Rudra** gain importance (they were **minor** in the Rigveda).
- **Indra** remains famous but is no longer the unchallenged centre of religion.

- Four **ashramas** (Brahmacharya → Grihastha → Vanaprastha → Sannyasa) and four **purusharthas** (Dharma, Artha, Kama, Moksha) are systematized in the post / Later Vedic horizon.
- **Pancha Mahayajnas** belong to the **Grihastha** (गृहस्थ) stage.
- About **sixteen samskaras** appear in later lists (from Garbhadhana to Antyeshti).
- Directional kingship titles in Later Vedic lists include **Samrat** (सम्राट) (east), **Svarat** (west), **Virat** (north), **Bhoja** (south), and **Raja** (centre).
- Thought shifts from **Brahmana** ritual manuals to forest **Aranyakas**.
- It then reaches the **Upanishads**, which put **jnana** (Brahman–Atman) over **yajna**.
- Untouchability as a clear social system is usually dated to the later **Dharmashastra** phase, not Early Rigvedic society.

> **Logic:** Trap — "Vishnu is already the supreme Rigvedic god." False. Trap — "Krishna Yajurveda = hymns to god Krishna." False; **Krishna** here means **Black** Yajurveda.

3.6 Political Institutions

Early: tribe + three assemblies check the rajan | Later: hereditary king + royal yajnas

- The political unit is the vis and the jana.
- Later it becomes a **janapada**.
- There is no written constitution. Custom and **dharma** rule.
- There is no standing army. A tribal **sena** fights under the senani.
- The **Battle of Ten Kings (Dasarajna)** is the core **Rigvedic** political event.
- Later Vedic kingship is advertised through big sacrifices.
- **Rajasuya** is consecration.
- **Ashvamedha** is the horse sacrifice that claims territory.
- **Vajapeya** is another royal rite.
- Some tribes keep **gana / sangha** oligarchy habits. Later Vajji and Licchavi echo this.

Battle of Ten Kings (Dasarajna) — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Rival tribal confederacies fought for pasture and river water in **Sapta Sindhu**.

Course: Bharata king **Sudas** of the Tritsu line, advised by **Vasishtha**, fought a **ten-king coalition** on the **Parushni (Ravi)**. **Visvamitra** stands on the opposite side in that tradition.

Result: Sudas **won**. The Bharata–Tritsu line became prominent in Rigvedic memory.

> **Logic:** Assemblies are strong in Rigvedic times. The **king is strong** in Later Vedic. **Sabha**, **Samiti**, and **Vidatha** are three distinct bodies.

3.7 Sabha

Smaller assembly of elders / nobles | advice + disputes

- It is a select gathering, not the whole tribe.
- It advises the rajan.
- It handles **disputes** and is more judicial than the Samiti.
- In **Rigvedic** hymns women could be present as **sabhavati** or **sabha vadhu**.
- In **Later Vedic** it becomes an elite-male club.
- Women drop out. The king is less bound by it.
- Later literature also uses *sabha* for a **gambling hall**. That is a social hall, not the early political body.
- The **Atharvaveda** calls **Sabha** and **Samiti** the **two daughters of Prajapati** and treats them as distinct institutions more clearly than the Rigveda.
- It is **not** Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha, or the 73rd-Amendment **Gram Sabha** (ग्राम सभा).

> **Logic:** Sabha means **elders**. Samiti means the **people**.

3.8 Samiti

General tribal assembly | broader than Sabha | elects / confirms the rajan

- It is the assembly of the freemen of the jana.
- War, migration, and **king-making** sit here in Early Vedic.
- Together with the Sabha it checks the chief.
- It is popular, not oligarchic.
- Women have little or no Samiti role. Early Sabha and Vidatha are more open.
- Later Vedic hereditary succession **kills** its electoral job. The body fades.

> **Logic:** Trap — “Samiti = Rajya Sabha.” Zero link.

3.9 Vidhata (Vidatha)

Oldest of the three | ritual + distribution + women | disappears first

- The syllabus spelling is **Vidhata**. Standard books say **Vidatha**. It is the same institution.
- Hymns show it as a **wide gathering**.
- It holds a feast, a **share-out of booty**, soma, and martial talk.
- It is not a law-court. Disputes lean toward the Sabha.
- **Women** sing and attend.
- It is more inclusive than the Later Vedic Sabha.
- It is the **first assembly to vanish** from Later Vedic texts.
- Among the three assemblies, **Vidatha** fades first from Later Vedic texts.

3.10 Vedic Literature

Oral Shruti | four layers per Veda | written down much later

- **Shruti** means "that which is heard."
- It covers Samhita, Brahmana, Aranyaka, and Upanishad.
- **Smriti** is later remembered law. It is not the core of this chapter.
- Growth order is **Samhita** (संहिता) (mantra), then **Brahmana** (ritual prose), then **Aranyaka** (forest and symbol), then **Upanishad** (उपनिषद्) (philosophy).
- **Karma-kanda** = Samhita + Brahmana (ritual). **Jnana-kanda** = Aranyaka + Upanishad (philosophy).
- **Trayi / Vedatrayi** = Rigveda + Yajurveda + Samaveda (the three liturgical Vedas). Atharvaveda is the fourth.
- The corpus is kept by **guru–shishya** recitation.
- **Shakhas** are recension schools. Patanjali cites **21** Rigveda branches.
- The Rigveda is the oldest Veda.
- The Atharvaveda and the prose layers are younger.
- Later Vedic books take shape in **Kuru–Panchala** and **Videha** in the east. Post-Vedic notes treat **Kuru–Panchala** as the axis of Aryan culture.
- **Sayana** of fourteenth-century Vijayanagara commented on the Vedas. He is **medieval**, not Vedic-age.
- An **Upadhyaya** teaches a portion of Veda / Vedanga for livelihood; an **Acharya** is a fuller teacher of the tradition.

> **Logic:** Vedas were **not** "published on paper" in 1500 BCE. Oral first.

3.11 Four Vedas

Rig · Sama · Yajur · Atharva | each has a Samhita core | compiler Vyasa

Veda	Core content	Priest	Upaveda	Main Samhita(s)	Key Brahmana(s)	Structure fact
Rigveda	Oldest; hymns (*rik*)	**Hotri / Hota**	**Ayurveda** (often also linked Atharva)	Rigveda Samhita	**Aitareya**, Kausitaki	**1028** hymns; **~10552** verses (*richas*); **10** mandalas
Samaveda (सामवेद)	Melodies (*saman*) for Soma	**Udgatri**	**Gandharvaveda**	Samaveda Samhita (mostly from Rig)	Tandya / Panchavimsha, Jaiminiya	Chant-book for sacrifice

Veda	Core content	Priest	Upaveda	Main Samhita(s)	Key Brahmana(s)	Structure fact
Yajurveda (यजुर्वेद)	Sacrificial formulas (*yajus*)	**Adhvaryu**	**Dhanurveda**	**Shukla:Vajasaneyi** (Madhyandina, Kanva; paper: **Vajasanami**). **Krishna:** Taittiriya, Kathaka, Maitrayani (+ Kapishthala)	**Shatapatha** (Shukla, **100** ch.); Taittiriya (Krishna)	Shukla = mantra & Brahmana **apart**; Krishna = **mixed**
Atharvaveda	Spells, healing, household	**Brahman** (rite supervisor)	**Arthashastra** (अर्थशास्त्र)	Atharvaveda Samhita	**Gopatha** (only one)	**20** books; newest of the four; early **iron** hints

- Mandalas **II–VII** are the family books and the oldest Rigvedic core (Gritsamada, Vishvamitra, Vamadeva, Atri, Bharadvaja, Vasishtha traditions).
- Mandala **VIII** is linked with Kanva and Angiras lines.
- Mandala **IX** is the Soma book (**114** hymns to Soma).
- Mandalas **I and X** are the latest.
- The **Purusha Sukta** lives in Mandala X.
- The **Gayatri Mantra** is RV **III.62.10**.
- It is addressed to **Savitr**. The seer is **Vishvamitra**.
- The Nasadiya Sukta, the creation hymn, is also in Mandala X.
- Most **Samaveda** verses are lifted from the Rigveda (about **1875** verses; only a small residue is not from Rig).
- **Shukla (White) Yajurveda** keeps mantra and Brahmana **apart**.
- **Krishna (Black) Yajurveda** mixes mantra and prose.
- In **- Here** Krishna **means the** Black Yajurveda **school (mantra + prose mixed). It does** not** mean the deity Krishna.
- The Atharvaveda is everyday religion, charms, healing, and household rites — not only royal yajna.
- First textual notice of **Anga** and **Magadha** (मगध) (with Gandhari and Mujavat) appears in the **Atharvaveda**.
- **Ayurveda** (science of life) is treated as an Upaveda / Upanga linked especially with the **Atharvaveda**.
- The supervising priest of the Atharvan rite is often called **Brahman**.

> **Logic:** Shukla Yajurveda = **Vajasaneyi** (also printed Vajasanami). Taittiriya / Maitrayani / Kathak = **Krishna (Black)** Yajurveda — not hymns to god Krishna.
>
> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2018, Q13]: Vajasaneyi Samhita** = Samhita of Shukla (White) Yajurveda (Madhyandina & Kanva recensions). *(See Q3 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*

3.12 Brahmanas

Prose manuals of yajna — not hymns

Brahmana	Veda
Aitareya, Kausitaki (Shankhayana)	Rigveda
Tandya / Panchavimsha, Jaiminiya	Samaveda
Shatapatha (largest, **100** chapters)	**Shukla Yajurveda**
Taittiriya	Krishna Yajurveda
Gopatha (only one)	Atharvaveda

- Brahmanas fix **how** to perform the sacrifice and **why** the myth says so.
- They set priest roles and varna duties.
- **Rajasuya** is treated in the Aitareya Brahmana.
- **Ashvamedha** is treated in the Shatapatha Brahmana.
- **Purushamedha** is also discussed in the **Shatapatha** (and in Taittiriya Brahmana notes).
- The **Shatapatha** also carries the Videha eastward-expansion story of **Videgha Mathava / Madhava** with priest **Gautama Rahugana** carrying Agni Vaisvanara east of the Sadaneera.
- The language is Later Vedic Sanskrit **prose**.
- They are the bridge toward Aranyakas.

> **Logic:** Brahmanas are **not** collections of hymns. Hymns sit in the Samhita.

3.13 Aranyakas

“Forest books” | symbol over public fire-altar | hinge to Upanishads

- They are meant for **vanaprastha** (वानप्रस्थ) hermits.
- They give a quieter, inward reading of ritual.
- The **Aitareya Aranyaka** belongs to the Rigveda.
- The **Taittiriya Aranyaka** belongs to the Krishna Yajurveda.
- The **Brihadaranyaka** sits on the Shatapatha / Shukla line.
- The Brihadaranyaka **is also an Upanishad**.
- Not every Veda has a fat separate Aranyaka.
- The Atharvaveda is thin here.
- The teaching is secretive. It is not the village public cult.

> **Logic:** An Aranyaka is not a Brahmana. Forest symbol is not public yajna prose. An Aranyaka is not an Upanishad, though the Brihadaranyaka overlaps.

3.14 Upanishads

Vedanta — Brahman and Atman | jnana over outer yajna

- Tradition counts **108** Upanishads.
- Notes use the principal early set: Brihadaranyaka, Chandogya, Isha, Kena, Katha, Mundaka, Mandukya, Prashna, Taittiriya, and Aitareya.
- **Svetasvatara** ("white horse" etymology in many notes) is often added to that list.
- **Moksha / salvation** as liberation language is developed in the **Upanishads**, not as a Rigvedic Samhita keyword.
- **Tat Tvam Asi** is taught in the **Chandogya**.
- Uddalaka Aruni speaks it to Shvetaketu.
- **Satyakama Jabala** appears in the **Chandogya**.
- The **Yajnavalkya–Maitreyi** and **Yajnavalkya–Gargi** dialogues are in the **Brihadaranyaka**.
- The Brihadaranyaka belongs to the Shukla Yajurveda.
- The **Nachiketa–Yama** story is in the **Katha Upanishad**.
- **Satyameva Jayate** ("Truth alone triumphs") is from the **Mundaka Upanishad** — India's national motto under the state emblem (adopted **26 January 1950**).
- **Tamaso mā jyotir gamaya** is from the **Brihadaranyaka**.
- The **Mandukya** is the shortest.
- It teaches **Om / AUM** and the four states of consciousness.
- **Janaka of Videha** patronises these debates. Other Upanishadic scholar-kings include **Asvapati of Kekaya**, Pravahana Jaivali of Panchala, and Ajatashatru of Kashi (in tradition).
- The date-band is about **800–600 BCE**, in eastern courts.
- Upanishads use **parables** (e.g. two-birds imagery) — they are not parable-free.

> **Logic:** Upanishads **question** big public yajna. They are **Shruti**. They are **not** a Vedanga.

3.14A Puranas and Itihasa (Vedic desk extras)

- There are **18** Mahapuranas. Five traditional marks (*pancha-lakshana*) are **Sarga, Pratisarga, Vamsha, Manvantara, and Vamshanucharita**.
- **Vishnu Purana** preserves Mauryan genealogical memory; **Vayu Purana** is often linked with Gupta-period material in booklet keys.
- The **Bhagavad Gita** (भगवद्गीता) is originally in **Sanskrit** (about **700** verses) inside the Mahabharata.
- The Mahabharata's early form is remembered as **Jaya / Jayasamhita** (~**8,800** verses); the expanded epic is called **Shatasahasri Samhita** (~**100,000** verses), attributed to **Vyasa** (व्यास).
- Ocean-churning myths name **Vasuki** as the churning rope.

3.15 Vedangas and Six Systems of Philosophy (Shad-Darshana)

- **Six Schools of Indian Philosophy (Shad-Darshana):** 1. **Samkhya:** Founded by **Kapila** (oldest system; reality consists of Purusha and Prakriti). 2. **Yoga:** Founded by **Patanjali** (author of *Yogasutra / Mahabhashya*). 3. **Nyaya:** Founded by **Gautama** (*Akshapada*; logical reasoning and valid knowledge). 4. **Vaisheshika:** Founded by **Kanada** (*Uluka*; atomic theory and physical reality). 5. **Purva Mimamsa:** Founded by **Jaimini** (ritualism and Vedic authority). 6. **Uttara Mimamsa (Vedanta):** Founded by **Badarayana** (Brahmasutra / philosophical monism).

Six limbs — tools to keep and decode the Veda | not Shruti philosophy

Vedanga	Job	Fact
Shiksha	Phonetics	Pratishakhya texts
Kalpa	Ritual sutras	**Shrauta** (public), **Grihya** (domestic), **Dharma** (law), **Sulba** (altar geometry — Baudhayana, Apastamba)
Vyakarana	Grammar	**Panini**, *Ashtadhyayi* (~5th c. BCE, edge of / just after Vedic)
Nirukta	Etymology	**Yaska**
Chhanda	Metre	**Pingala**
Jyotisha	Ritual calendar / astronomy	Vedanga Jyotisha

Memory: **S-K-V-N-C-J**.

> **Logic:** Upanishad / Puranas / Itihasa are **not** Vedangas. Yaska ≠ Panini.

3.16 Painted Grey Ware (PGW)

Archaeological marker of Later Vedic culture | ~1100–600 BCE | upper Gangetic–Ghaggar belt

- **Painted Grey Ware** is fine grey pottery with geometric designs painted in black. It is the standard archaeological signature of the **Later Vedic** phase in the doab.
- The date-band is about **1100–600 BCE**, overlapping the end of the Vedic textual period. Sites often sit on top of or beside **OCP** layers.
- Distribution runs through **western UP, Haryana, Punjab, and Rajasthan**: Hastinapur, Ahichchhatra, Kurukshetra, Mathura, Jakhera, and Panipat are textbook names.
- PGW settlements are mostly villages, but some grow into **fortified towns** with moats and palisades before the full mahajanapada cities.
- The culture is linked in tradition to **Kuru–Panchala** and the Mahabharata geography. Archaeology does **not** by itself prove every epic event.
- PGW layers show **iron** tools and weapons along with horse bones and ivory work. That is why PGW marks the **early Iron Age** in the north.
- Stratigraphy usually runs **OCP → PGW → NBPW** in the doab. PGW is **not** the same as Harappan red ware or megalithic black-and-red ware of the south.

> **Logic:** PGW = **Later Vedic / doab**, not Sangam south. PGW comes **before** NBPW, not after.

3.17 Iron Age in India

Metal transition that reshapes agriculture, war, and settlement | north and south follow different pottery tracks

- The Rigveda knows metal as **ayas**, usually read as **copper or bronze**. True iron appears in Later Vedic texts as **shyama ayas** or **krishna ayas** (“dark metal”).
- In **north India**, iron technology spreads with **PGW** from about the 12th century BCE and then with **NBPW** cities after about 700 BCE.
- Iron ploughshares, axes, and weapons made dense farming and forest clearance possible in the Ganga plain. That underpins the **second urbanisation** and the sixteen mahajanapadas.
- In **south and central India**, the Iron Age is often studied through **megalithic** burials with **black-and-red ware**, not through PGW.
- Key southern megalithic names include **Brahmagiri**, **Adichanallur**, **Maski** (मास्की), and **Hallur**. Burial types include dolmens, cists, stone circles, and **hero stones (virakkal)**.
- Iron did **not** arrive everywhere at one instant. Gandhara, the doab, and the Deccan show different start-dates in excavation.

Region	Iron Age marker	Period fact
Northwest / doab	PGW then NBPW	Later Vedic → mahajanapada
South / Deccan	Megaliths + black-and-red ware	Pre-Sangam bed
Chalcolithic overlap	Limited copper before iron	Mehrgarh, Jorwe, OCP zones

> **Logic:** “Iron in Rigveda” is a **trap** unless the question means Later Vedic shyama ayas. PGW iron is **north**; megalithic iron is mainly **peninsular**.

UP Focus

Fact	Detail
Later Vedic **core**	**Ganga–Yamuna doab** — western–central UP
Kuru	Delhi–Haryana–Meerut belt; Hastinapur tradition
Panchala	Rohilkhand–central doab (Ahichchhatra near Bareilly)
Kosala	Eastern UP (later Ayodhya / Shravasti world)
Kashi	Varanasi

Fact	Detail
Videha	North Bihar (Janaka) — east of UP, linked in Shatapatha
PGW sites	**Hastinapur** (Meerut), **Atranjikhera** (Etah), **Ahichchhatra**, Noh (Rajasthan)
Rigvedic	**Not** a UP heartland — Punjab / Sapta Sindhu